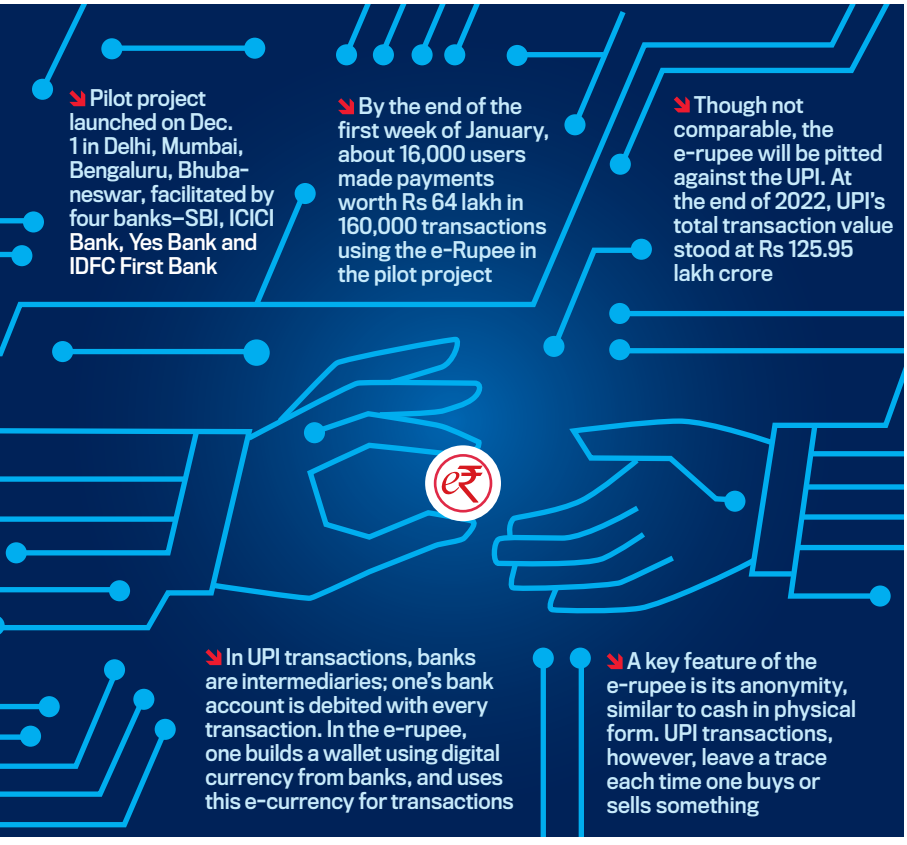
in 2023. But given that no assurances have been given by the party leadership, no one, not even Sharma, is keen to hazard a guess on his eventual fate. "It would not be correct for me to answer questions about my continuation. This is something within the domain of the national party president and he will decide," Sharma told INDIA TODAY, when asked about his future.

He also did not dwell on possible changes in the MP cabinet. When asked if the Gujarat formula of large-scale changes to beat anti-incumbency would be done in MP too, Sharma said the central leadership "does regular assessments of the work done by the government and the party organisation" and decisions regarding any change will be taken by them on that basis. This overarching presence the central leadership seems to have in state affairs—even in a state like MP that has a popular, long-serving CM—may paradoxically go in Sharma's favour. Observers feel New Delhi will exercise a much bigger role in the 2023 polls, as has been the trend of late. In such a scenario, many decisions of the state president may actually be coming from the central leadership, including those on candidate selection.

Meanwhile, the list of 'potential replacements' for Chouhan has grown in recent months. A couple of ministers in Chouhan's cabinet have positioned themselves as potential choices, but have nothing concrete to show by way of any sign from New Delhi. While not impossible, the likelihood of Chouhan being replaced is low for now, say sources. Simple reason: he remains the BJP's best bet for a victory in MP, with the showcasing of 'Brand Modi' adding ballast to its efforts. (The frequency of Modi-Shah's trips to MP has greatly increased lately.) Also, an eleventh hour change can always seem like an advance acceptance of defeat. ■

E-RUPEE

Experimenting with the e-Rupee



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

By M.G. Arun

At the Winter Olympics in Beijing last February, visitors were in for a surprise. They could, once they had scanned their passports, exchange their foreign currency for eCNY, an electronic form of the Chinese Yuan–the digital currency from the People's Bank of China, the nation's central bank. All that the visitors needed to do was use a card or a mobile app to spend this digital currency for purchases at the Olympic Village. Could something similar materialise in India anytime soon?

It could, but for that a low-key experimentation by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) currently underway in four cities needs to find more success than is being ascribed to it now. The central bank had launched a pilot project of its digital currency, the e-rupee, on December 1. Just weeks into the experiment, though, there is a general apprehension regarding the way it's going. By the end of the first week of January, about 16,000 users had made payments worth some Rs 64 lakh in a total of 160,000 transactions using the e-rupee. Those numbers can offer only a partial picture at present, though. It's difficult to bracket them conclusively one way or the other because of the limited nature of the pilot project.

As of now, only four banks–the State Bank of India, ICICI Bank, Yes Bank and IDFC First Bank–are facilitating the pilot programme, launched in Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Bhubaneswar, which is being strictly controlled by the RBI. Four more banks–the Bank of Baroda,